

LG Energy Solution (373220.KS): Core 2Q OP margins miss; focus likely on ESS margins outlook on the analyst call; Buy

LG Energy Solution (LGES) released 2Q26 preliminary earnings on Jul 7th. Ex-AMPC revenue of W7.3tn (+15% QoQ, +32% YoY) was largely in-line with GSe/Bloomberg consensus of W7.0tn/W7.4tn. AMPC of W241bn, implies a sequential recovery in US battery shipment to c.5 GWh (vs. c.4 GWh in 1Q26 and c.10 GWh in 2Q25). We believe the sequential topline recovery was led by the ESS ramp and continued small-cylindrical strength (resilient Tesla demand), while US EV pouch volumes likely stayed constrained by the well-flagged GM JV downtime.

LGES returned to operating profit in 2Q at W113bn (1Q26: -W208bn, 2Q25: W492bn) but was behind GSe/Bloomberg consensus of W224bn/W204bn. Excluding AMPC, the OP margin improved sequentially to -1.7% (vs. -6.2% in 1Q26 and 0% in 2Q25). With revenue broadly in-line, we see the softer core margin as driven by potential two factors: (1) OEM take-or-pay compensation timing; and (2) ESS conversion costs from simultaneous line conversions.

What to expect on the 2Q26 earnings call (on 30 Jul)

We expect the following key debates and questions to be discussed during the 2Q26 earnings call:

- **Path to core profitability.** Timing of the OP-accretive compensation tranche and the shape of the 2H26 recovery.
- **ESS ramp and fixed-cost absorption.** How much converted-line start-up cost is already in the run-rate versus a 3Q headwind.
- **ESS margins into potential overcapacity.** Whether double-digit ESS margins hold as Ford and other entrants add capacity.
- **GM JV restart.** The shape of the 3Q restart and its pull-through to 4Q US EV utilization.
- **Europe strategy.** How fast European plants utilization rate can improve and turn profitable as BEV registrations recover.
- **Next-gen chemistries and technologies.** Commercialization timelines for dry electrode and ASSB versus incumbent LFP and high-nickel.

Earnings, Valuations and Key Risks:

We maintain our Buy rating and TP of W520,000. **Key downside risks:** (1)

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Lower-than-expected market share; (2) Slower-than-expected ramp-up of new EV/ESS battery plant lines; (3) Lower global EV penetration rate

Thesis in Key Charts

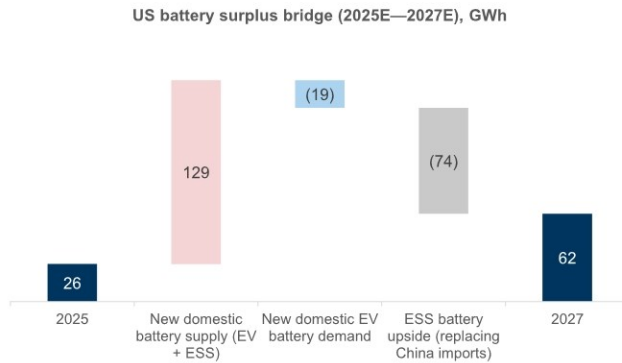
Exhibit 1: LGES quarterly revenue and OP trend

(Wbn)	4Q23	1Q24	2Q24	3Q24	4Q24	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26P
Revenue (ex-IRA)*	8,001	6,129	6,162	6,878	6,451	6,265	5,565	5,700	6,142	6,365	7,319
OP	338	157	195	448	(226)	375	492	601	(122)	(208)	113
OP (ex-IRA)	88	(32)	(252)	(18)	(603)	(83)	1	236	(455)	(398)	(128)
OPM	4.2%	2.6%	3.2%	6.5%	-3.5%	6.0%	8.8%	10.5%	-2.0%	-3.3%	1.5%
OPM (ex-IRA)	1.1%	-0.5%	-4.1%	-0.3%	-9.3%	-1.3%	0.0%	4.1%	-7.4%	-6.2%	-1.7%

*Company includes the IRA AMPC in reported revenue from 1Q26. We have excluded AMPC in our illustration for trend comparison with historical quarters.

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: US Battery Surplus Bridge

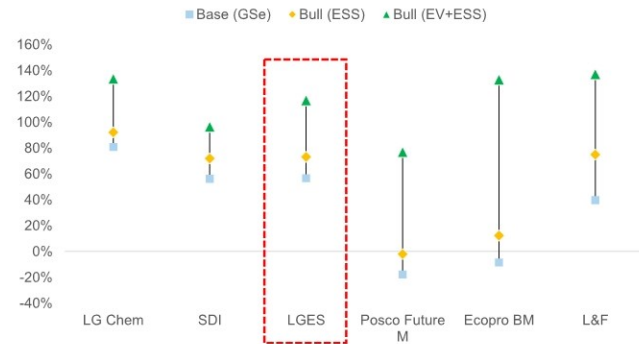


*Excluding VW supply and assuming 100% ESS TAM goes to ex-China cell makers.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Current LGES price sits below our base case, with upside across all three scenarios

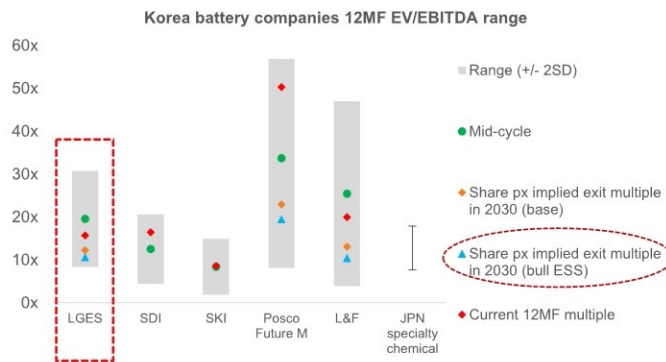
Base/Bull(ESS)/Bull(EV+SS) valuation scenarios relative to the last closing price



Priced as of 7th Jul 2026 close. Bull (ESS) assumes higher long term ESS shipments/market share/margins, Bull (EV + ESS) assumes Bull (ESS) along with higher long term EV shipments/market share/margins.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Refinitiv Eikon

Exhibit 4: LGES share price implied exit EBITDA multiple is now closer to the lower end of the stock's 12m forward historical range.



Priced as of 7th Jul 2026 close.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Investment Thesis - LG Energy Solution

LGES is the largest battery manufacturer outside China, with leadership in high nickel battery chemistries. We remain positive on LGES' fundamentals given its widening global technology leadership in batteries with upcoming commercial production of new technology battery products such as large size cylindrical 4680 batteries, cell-to-pack LFP batteries (from 2025) and dry electrode process (from 2028). Meanwhile, we see market share growth in the US, driven by rapidly expanding capacities where we expect the company's US market share growth to be margins and returns accretive (GSe 2026E-28E EBITDA CAGR of 51% and 6.5% CROCI expansion during this period).

While the market is anchored on near-term EV battery weakness, we believe it is underestimating the emerging clearer path to utilization rate recovery which we estimate to rise from ~42% in FY26E to ~67% in 2028E. We also see improving visibility in medium-term earnings (doubling of EBITDA between FY26E-28E), supported by ESS demand and strong order momentum for new products. We are Buy rated on LGES.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - LG Energy Solution

We are Buy rated on LGES with a 12m TP of W520,000 derived using a 50%/50% blend of DCF (WACC: 8.4%, TGR: 3.3%) and 2027E/28E EV/EBITDA. We apply a mid-cycle 20x multiple to adjusted (ex-JV share) 2027E/28E EBITDA.

Key downside risks: (1) Lower-than-expected market share; (2) Slower-than-expected ramp-up of new EV/ESS battery plant lines; (3) Lower global EV penetration rate

373220.KS	12m Price Target: W520,000	Price: W332,000	Upside: 56.6%
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Buy		GS Forecast			
Market cap: W77.7tr / \$50.7bn Enterprise value: W106.3tr / \$69.4bn 3m ADTV: W219.6bn / \$146.2mn South Korea Korea EV Battery M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes		12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
	Revenue (W bn)	23,671.8	28,297.7	39,259.1	50,283.8
	EBITDA (W bn)	5,037.4	5,418.3	8,522.5	12,415.1
	EPS (W)	(4,585)	(1,014)	8,438	19,333
	P/E (X)	NM	NM	39.3	17.2
	P/B (X)	4.2	3.9	3.5	2.9
	Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	3.7	3.1	1.8	0.8
	CROCI (%)	6.6	9.4	12.5	15.9
	FCF yield (%)	(6.5)	0.4	2.2	5.5
		3/26	6/26E	9/26E	12/26E
	EPS (W)	(4,763,191)	1,428	1,500,493	2,247,338

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 7 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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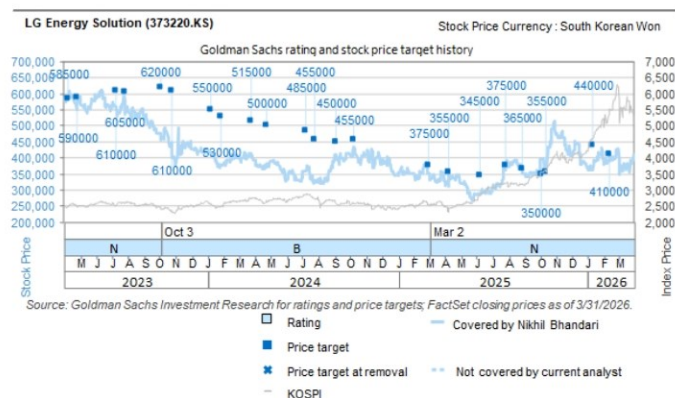
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Target price history table(s)

LG Energy Solution (373220.KS)

Date of report	Target price (W)	Closing price (W)
01-Jun-26	520,000	455,000
11-Feb-26	410,000	392,000
11-Jan-26	440,000	363,000
13-Oct-25	355,000	360,000
03-Oct-25	350,000	399,000
28-Aug-25	365,000	364,000
27-Jul-25	375,000	363,500
08-Jun-25	345,000	291,000
10-Apr-25	355,000	349,500
02-Mar-25	375,000	352,000
08-Oct-24	455,000	436,500
04-Sep-24	450,000	399,500
25-Jul-24	455,000	332,500
08-Jul-24	485,000	358,500
25-Apr-24	500,000	372,500
25-Mar-24	515,000	414,500
28-Jan-24	530,000	381,000
09-Jan-24	550,000	417,500
25-Oct-23	610,000	409,500
03-Oct-23	620,000	476,500
27-Jul-23	605,000	540,000
09-Jul-23	610,000	-

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